Guitar Exercises - Level 105

FINAL MUSICIANSHIP CAPSTONE

The Complete 105-Level Core Curriculum Examination

This is Level 105 of 105. HARD STOP. There is no Level 106 in the universal core curriculum.

The final level does not introduce a new technique, scale, chord system, or genre. It tests whether the player can integrate everything already learned into complete musical decisions under realistic constraints.

Module	Examination area	Events
A	Technique and fretboard command	160
B	Harmony, voicing, and voice-leading command	160
C	Rhythm, groove, and style command	160
D	Ear training and transcription command	160
E	Improvisation and expressive phrasing	160
F	Repertoire reconstruction and adaptation	160
G	Arrangement and ensemble-role command	144
H	Composition and real-time authorship	160
I	Recovery, memory, and performance resilience	128
J	Final 60-minute integrated musicianship examination	480
	TOTAL	1872

Final principle: musicianship is the ability to hear, understand, choose, execute, recover, and complete.

What Level 105 Actually Tests

Domain	Not merely...	But whether you can...
Technique	play fast drills	choose and execute technique without disrupting music
Fretboard	name notes	find harmonic targets immediately in useful registers
Harmony	recite chord theory	voice-lead and reharmonize in context
Rhythm	count subdivisions	create stable, style-appropriate pocket
Ear	identify intervals	reconstruct usable music from sound
Improvisation	play licks	develop remembered ideas over form
Repertoire	memorize parts	reconstruct, adapt, and recover complete pieces
Composition	generate ideas	finish coherent original work
Performance	avoid mistakes	continue musically when mistakes occur

A player may simplify any passage during the exam. Simplification is scored by whether it preserves musical function.

Final Examination Rules

Rule	Standard
No perfection requirement	mistakes are allowed; unmanaged collapse is not
No restart culture	recovery is part of the score
No technique-for-technique's-sake	every technical choice must serve a musical role
No mandatory genre identity	groove mechanics matter more than labels
No single correct voicing	function, register, and voice-leading matter
No endless revision	final versions must be declared
No hidden crutches	memory, ear, and fallback versions are tested
No Level 106	future study becomes specialization, repertoire, and artistic development

The final capstone is not a graduation from guitar. It is graduation from the universal core curriculum.

Module A - Technique and Fretboard Command

Station	Task
1	Play chromatic/finger-independence warm-up at controlled tempo, then stop exactly on cue.
2	Locate C, F#, Bb, and E in at least five fretboard positions each.
3	Play major, natural minor, harmonic minor, melodic minor, and pentatonic material in connected positions.
4	Execute alternate, economy, legato, hybrid, and sweep-style motions at musically controlled speed.
5	Perform one string-skipping phrase and one cross-string arpeggio without excess noise.
6	Demonstrate bends, vibrato, slides, harmonics, rakes, muted attacks, and one volume/tone articulation.
7	Switch between chordal and single-note roles without stopping.
8	Repeat the station at 80% speed with cleaner execution than the first pass.

Technique passes only if timing, muting, and musical control survive the exercise.

Module A - Fretboard Reaction Test

Prompt	Time limit
Find degree 3 of C major in three registers	5 sec
Find b7 of A7 in three positions	5 sec
Find 7 of E harmonic minor	5 sec
Find 3 of G7, then resolve to 3 of Cmaj7	5 sec
Find b5 of Bm7b5	5 sec
Play 1-3-5-7 of Dmaj7 from nearest position	5 sec
Transpose 1-b3-4-5 motif from A to C	8 sec
Play same target in low/mid/high register	8 sec

Searching across frets after the timer starts lowers the score. Silent location before one decisive attack is preferred.

Module B - Harmony, Voicing, and Voice Leading

Station	Task
1	Voice I-vi-IV-V in one key using open/full chords, then triads, then shells.
2	Voice ii-V-I in three major keys using nearest inversions.
3	Voice iiø-V-i in three minor keys.
4	Add one secondary dominant without breaking melodic top line.
5	Connect two chords with a passing diminished chord.
6	Hold one pedal tone across four changing chords.
7	Create one descending bass reharmonization.
8	Reduce full voicings to bass + guide tone + melody.

The player must explain the purpose of each chromatic chord in one sentence.

Module B - Fixed Melody Reharmonization

Top note	Create at least three supporting harmonies
E	
G	
C	
F#	
Bb	
A	

For each top note: state chord function, bass direction, and whether the note acts as chord tone, extension, or controlled tension.

Module C - Rhythm, Groove, and Style Command

Groove engine	Required behavior
Straight rock	eighth-note drive + note-length control
Funk/R&B	16th ghost hierarchy + short stabs
Reggae/Ska	offbeat placement + clipped duration
Soul/Motown	backbeat/repeated figure + bass space
Country/Americana	alternating bass + chord answer
Shuffle/Swing	triplet spacing without flattening
Interlocking groove	repeated upper cell around bass/percussion
Jam-band	motif + space + density development

Perform all eight at one master tempo first. The groove identity must come from placement, duration, accent, register, and space.

Module C - Groove Switching Test

Bars	Command
1-2	Straight rock
3-4	Funk
5-6	Reggae
7-8	Soul
9-10	Country
11-12	Shuffle
13-14	Interlock
15-16	Jam-band

No reset bar. Same harmony and tempo. A partner/randomizer may alter the order.

Module D - Ear Training and Transcription Command

Pass	Listen for
1	pulse/form
2	bass/root motion
3	chord quality/function
4	groove/note length
5	melodic hook/targets
6	register/texture
7	ending/cue behavior

Use an unfamiliar 8-16 bar recording or partner-created source. No chart on first pass.

Module D - Transcription Deliverable

Item	Required
Form map	section labels + bar counts
Bass map	structural notes + inversions
Harmony	functional chord map
Groove	subdivision + attack/length pattern
Hook	one signature riff/melodic landmark
S/C/O classification	structural/color/optional details
Performance version	functional reconstruction
Reduced version	roots/shells + landmarks

The goal is not forensic imitation. The goal is a defensible reconstruction that preserves structure and identity.

Module E - Improvisation and Expressive Phrasing

Station	Task
1	Improvise 8 bars using only chord tones and rests.
2	Repeat with one 3-4 note motif developed across the form.
3	Pre-hear and sing one target before each chord change.
4	Use one planned rhythmic displacement.
5	Use one planned bend/vibrato climax.
6	Use one full-bar silence.
7	Return to original motif after contrast.
8	End with a clear phrase-level cadence.

The solo is scored for memory, development, target choice, dynamics, restraint, and ending - not for note count.

Module E - Expression Arc

Bars	Intensity	Allowed focus
1-2	1-2	plain notes, slides, narrow vibrato
3-4	2-3	rakes, pre-bends, register lift
5-6	3-4	one real climax
7	2	decompression
8	1	plain resolution or rest

If the peak is not obvious, reduce bars 1-4 and 7-8 rather than adding more to bars 5-6.

Module F - Repertoire Reconstruction and Adaptation

Task	Requirement
Cold-start one known piece	begin from silence without intro rehearsal
Start from bridge/chorus	retrieve from internal form map
Perform 100% version	complete arrangement
Perform 50% version	groove + hook + landmarks
Transpose first section	new key, same function
Adapt for one guitar	combine essential roles
Adapt for full band	remove redundant guitar information
Recover one injected failure	no restart

Use public-domain material, original work, or repertoire you already have lawful access to.

Module G - Arrangement and Ensemble-Role Command

Scenario	Create guitar role
Solo guitar	bass + harmony + melody hierarchy
Power trio	clear harmonic implication, leave bass space
Two guitars	split register and responsibility
Guitar + keys	shells/triads, avoid duplication
Vocal support	leave phrase endings and vocal register clear
Full ensemble	minimum necessary guitar density
Solo section	support simplifies as lead intensifies
Final chorus	peak without doubling every role

For one 8-bar progression, create all eight arrangement scenarios.

Module H - Composition and Real-Time Authorship

Station	Task
1	Generate one 3-4 note motif.
2	Write or improvise an 8-bar A section.
3	Create contrasting B using two changed variables.
4	Create one bridge/departure.
5	Return to A with one variation.
6	Add one clear dynamic peak.
7	Create an ending rather than stopping randomly.
8	Perform a reduced 50% version.

The piece may be prepared shortly before the exam or generated in real time, but the form must be coherent and memorable.

Module H - Real-Time Composition Randomizer

Cue	Action
Repeat	state last idea exactly
Vary	change one variable only
Contrast	introduce B material
Reharmonize	change harmony under identity anchor
Space	half/full-bar rest
Build	increase one intensity variable
Return	restore A identity
End	construct cadence/release

Use random cues every 2-4 bars. The piece must retain memory despite unknown decisions.

Module I - Recovery, Memory, and Performance Resilience

Injected failure	Required response
Wrong chord	nearest correct function at next landmark
Lost form	roots + section landmark
Forgot fill	omit it
Forgot solo phrase	target + rest
Groove collapses	simplify to primary pulse
Wrong patch/tone	play simplified role until safe change
Bend/harmonic fails	plain target and continue
Missed ending cue	follow authoritative cutoff

The recovery should make the mistake smaller, not larger.

Module I - Memory Retrieval Test

Prompt	Time limit
First chord/count-in of known piece	5 sec
Bridge entrance	8 sec
Outro	8 sec
Emergency version of chorus	5 sec
Primary motif of original	5 sec
Function map of ii-V-I in random key	8 sec
Groove engine from verbal cue	5 sec
Target note over random chord	5 sec

The curriculum ends with retrieval, not with page-turning dependency.

Module J - Final 60-Minute Integrated Musicianship Examination

Block	Minutes	Task
1	0-8	Technique + fretboard reaction
2	8-16	Harmony + voicing + reharmonization
3	16-24	Groove/style switching
4	24-32	Ear/transcription reconstruction
5	32-40	Improvisation + expression
6	40-48	Repertoire adaptation + recovery
7	48-56	Original composition/arrangement performance
8	56-60	Reflection + final declaration

The exact minute count may shift slightly, but the entire exam should be completed in one session with minimal interruption.

Final Examination - Block 1: Technique and Fretboard

Minute	Task
0-2	short warm-up + picking/legato control
2-4	random note/degree location
4-6	scale/arpeggio connection through two positions
6-8	bend/vibrato/harmonic/articulation accuracy

Score execution and immediate fretboard access equally.

Final Examination - Block 2: Harmony and Voicing

Minute	Task
8-10	major ii-V-I in random key
10-12	minor iiø-V-i in random key
12-14	fixed top-note reharmonization
14-16	one secondary dominant + one passing diminished / pedal solution

Explain every non-diatonic chord before moving on.

Final Examination - Block 3: Groove and Style

Minute	Task
16-18	straight rock -> funk
18-20	reggae/ska -> soul
20-22	country -> shuffle
22-24	interlock -> jam-band

Same tempo and harmony unless otherwise chosen. Style change must be audible without effects.

Final Examination - Block 4: Ear and Reconstruction

Minute	Task
24-26	form/pulse from unfamiliar excerpt
26-28	bass/root map
28-30	harmony/groove
30-32	hook + functional performance

Do not spend the entire block chasing one uncertain extension.

Final Examination - Block 5: Improvisation and Expression

Minute	Task
32-34	targets only
34-36	motif development
36-38	dynamic/expression arc
38-40	random cue: Return / Space / Build / End

One clear motif return and one clear ending are mandatory.

Final Examination - Block 6: Repertoire Adaptation

Minute	Task
40-42	cold-start known piece
42-44	start from middle section
44-46	adapt section to new ensemble role/key
46-48	recover one injected failure and continue

A successful recovery is worth more than preserving a difficult but failing original part.

Final Examination - Block 7: Original Work

Minute	Task
48-50	state identity/form of original
50-55	perform complete original or condensed core version
55-56	perform 50% reduction / alternate arrangement

The work must sound authored: identity, form, development, return, and ending.

Final Examination - Block 8: Reflection and Final Declaration

Question	Answer in one sentence
What is your strongest domain?	
What still needs specialization?	
Which fallback saved the most performances?	
Which technique do you now use less because you understand it better?	
What is the next repertoire/composition goal?	
What specialization track will you pursue, if any?	

The core curriculum ends with self-directed musicianship. Future study should be chosen by musical goal, not by an arbitrary next level number.

Final Scoring Rubric

Domain	0	1	2	3
Technique/fretboard	breaks/unknown	basic	controlled	immediate + musical
Harmony/voicing	wrong	basic	functional	voice-led + adaptive
Rhythm/groove	unstable	keeps time	stylistic	deep pocket + switching
Ear/transcription	cannot reconstruct	partial	functional	fast + selective
Improvisation	random	phrases	develops motif	coherent arc
Repertoire	fragile	memorized	adaptable	resilient + transferable
Arrangement	cluttered	basic	role-aware	orchestrated
Composition	fragment	complete	coherent	distinct + revisable
Recovery	stops	recovers late	simplifies	seamless
Performance	fragmented	complete	convincing	commanding + musical

Maximum: 30 points.

Graduation Standard

Outcome	Requirement
CORE COMPLETE	24/30 or better
No-zero rule	No zero in Rhythm/Groove, Ear/Transcription, Recovery, or Performance
Performance rule	Complete final session without abandoning the exam
Original-work rule	One finished original must be presented
Repertoire rule	One complete adapted piece must be presented
Repeatability rule	Pass on two separate days OR pass once with an independent listener/reviewer scoring 24+

A score below 24 does not create Level 106. It identifies which earlier domain should be revisited.

If a Domain Does Not Pass

Weak domain	Return to
Technique/fretboard	earlier technique, scale, arpeggio, picking, or fretboard levels
Harmony/voicing	triads, CAGED, 7ths, guide tones, chord melody
Rhythm/groove	Section XII
Ear/transcription	Levels 76-78 and 97
Improvisation	Levels 73-79 and 103
Repertoire	Section XIV
Arrangement	Levels 80-84, 98, 102
Composition	Section XV
Recovery/performance	Levels 79, 95-99

The curriculum becomes a diagnostic map rather than an endless staircase.

CORE CURRICULUM COMPLETION

Level 105 marks the end of the universal guitar curriculum.

The completed path has moved through:

From	To
Finger control	complete technical choice
Shapes	fretboard understanding
Scales	harmonic targeting
Chords	voice leading
Counting	groove
Licks	motif development
Listening	transcription
Practice pieces	repertoire
Execution	arrangement
Improvisation	real-time composition
Ideas	finished original work
Avoiding mistakes	musical recovery

There is no Level 106.

From here, the guitarist advances through repertoire, collaboration, performance, recording, composition, and specialization tracks rather than a universal numbered sequence.

Post-Core Specialization Map

Track	Possible focus
Lead / Rock	advanced phrasing, speed, tone, repertoire
Metal / Technical	precision, extended-range, advanced picking/tapping
Jazz / Harmony	standards, substitutions, comping, chord melody
Blues	vocabulary, phrasing, ensemble interaction
Country	hybrid picking, pedal-steel language, repertoire
Fingerstyle	independence, arrangements, classical/folk techniques
Rhythm / Funk / R&B	deep pocket, comping, ensemble role
Songwriting / Composition	lyrics, larger forms, production
Session / Studio	sight-reading, patch discipline, part creation
Live Performance	set building, cues, recovery, stage craft

These are not Levels 106+. They are branches chosen according to musical goals.

FINAL HARD STOP

The 105-level universal guitar curriculum is complete.

Future work should now answer a different question:

What music do you want to make, and what specialized skills does that music require?

If the answer is unclear, choose repertoire. Repertoire will expose the next real weakness more reliably than inventing another generic level.